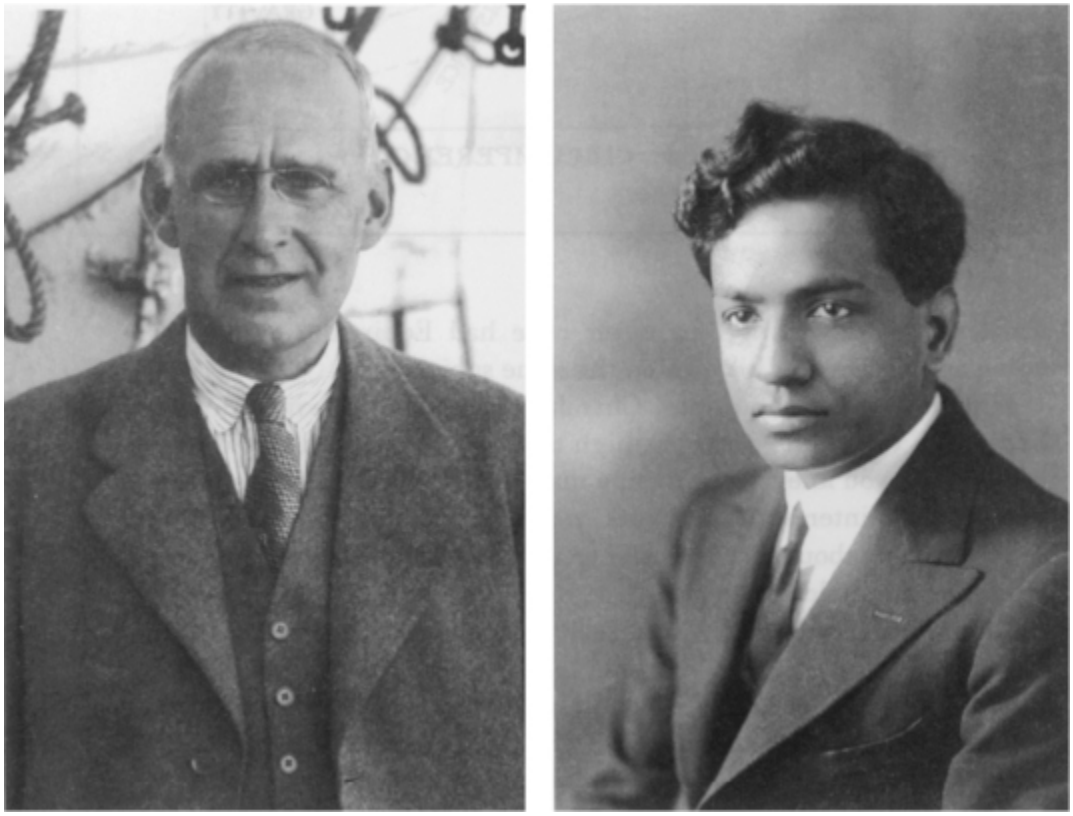


Left: **Arthur Stanley Eddington in 1932.** ***Right:*** **Subrahmanyan Chandrasekhar in 1934.** [Left: courtesy UPI/Bettmann; right: courtesy S. Chandrasekhar.]

At last the meeting started. Time dragged by as the Society president made various announcements, and various astronomers gave miscellaneous talks. At last it was Chandrasekhar's turn. Suppressing his anxiety, he gave an impeccable presentation, emphasizing particularly his maximum mass for white dwarfs.

After polite applause from the fellows of the Society, the president invited Eddington to speak.

Eddington began gently, by reviewing the history of white-dwarf research. Then, gathering steam, he described the disturbing implications of Chandrasekhar's maximum-mass result:

In Chandrasekhar's diagram of the mass of a star plotted vertically and its circumference plotted horizontally (Figure 4.4), there is only one set of masses and circumferences for which gravity can be counterbalanced by nonthermal pressure (pressure that remains after the star turns cold): that of white dwarfs. In the region to the left of Chandrasekhar's white-dwarf curve (shaded region; stars with smaller circumferences), the star's nonthermal degeneracy pressure completely overwhelms gravity. The degeneracy